

Project 8

Course Code and Name: MSJ 11241 Interpersonal and Intercultural Communication

Project Name: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Barriers

Project Type: Reflective Paper

Semester of Submission: Spring 2025

Project Description:

The project defines culture and the ways it is expressed (language, non-verbal communication, art, traditions, and social norms), and explains why intercultural communication skills matter in academic, professional, and diplomatic settings. The paper then analyzes two scenarios: adapting as a Bangladeshi student to the UK's educational and social environment, and understanding Bangladesh-Japan communication differences using Hofstede's six cultural dimensions (power distance, individualism vs. collectivism, masculinity, uncertainty avoidance, long-term orientation, and indulgence).

Project Justification:

This topic was chosen to reflect on my own potential experience navigating unfamiliar cultural environments and to apply theoretical frameworks, such as cultural relativism and Hofstede's dimensions, to real cross-cultural scenarios. Understanding these differences is directly relevant to my field of media studies and journalism, where working with diverse audiences and international collaborators requires cultural awareness and adaptability.



ULAB
**UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
BANGLADESH**

Final Project

MSJ 11241: Interpersonal and Intercultural Communication

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Reflective Paper on Intercultural Communication and Cultural Barriers

What is culture?

Culture represents the common beliefs, values, customs and behaviors with accompanying artifacts which define a particular group of individuals. Through culture people develop their thinking patterns along with their way of communication and behavior that allows them to connect with others. Language, customs, rituals, artistic appearances, and social structures are all ways that human societies pass on their history to future generations.

How We Express Culture

Working people demonstrate culture through multiple expressions which include:

1. The words we utilize together with our spoken expressions and particular linguistic terms form language as a cultural expression.
2. Non-verbal communication: Gestures, eye contact, body language.
3. Art, music, dance as well as storytelling typically display cultural identity through creative works.
4. Celestial events with holidays combined with ceremonies, dress codes and food habits make up traditional cultural practices.
5. Social norms alongside values determine our standard definitions for respect as well as politeness and gender roles alongside our sense of time orientation and more.

Importance of Understanding Intercultural Communication

Gaining intercultural communication skills is crucial for developing empathy amongst individuals from various cultural backgrounds. People can enhance their interactions with others while recognizing their own biases thanks to the skills they have learned. The global trend toward greater interconnection demands effective intercultural communication in order to support cooperation between multinational corporations, diplomatic missions, educational institutions, and multifunctional media groups working toward common goals. Since misunderstandings between people are often the cause of cultural disputes, effective intercultural communication helps to avoid them. Through the development of adaptation, cultural

intelligence, and emotional sensitivity, these communication skills aid in the construction of both personal and professional growth, making them desirable in multicultural environments.

Problem A

As a Bangladeshi student, the transition from the Bangladeshi to the UK educational environment during the exchange program causes both positive engagement and social adaptation challenges. The barriers and adaptations I may have to face are:-

1. **Language and Communication Style:** When combined with the UK's unique communication traits, like speech accents and regional expressions of language, the English language's frequent use in both Bangladesh and the UK creates communication barriers. Since their upbringing encourages direct, literal communication techniques, me as a student may become confused by the British use of indirect speech, humor, and understatement in interactions.
2. **Social Norms and Etiquette:** A family-centered collectivist structure, communal ties, and customs of hospitality are the primary features of Bangladeshi culture. The social atmosphere in the UK places a higher value on each person's personal boundaries, independence, and privacy than the general Bangladeshi population does. As a Bangladeshi student who prefers longer-running talks during greetings finds that a British "hello" or polite nod conveys an emotionless impression.
3. **Ethnocentrism:** When compared to what I believe to be Bangladeshi traditions in areas like religious practices, as well as clothing and eating norms, I frequently find British customs to be unattractive and less useful when I first encounter them. An instance of ethnocentrism is when someone judges another culture according to their own standards. Bangladeshis may mistakenly interpret the British society's irregular community events and religious involvement as an indication of a lack of cultural values.
4. **Cultural Relativism:** Cultural relativism is the strategy I would employ to deal with these difficulties in order to understand other cultures without making judgments. Being aware

of British cultural norms around formality, privacy, and timeliness would help me collaborate with others more productively and respectfully.

5. Cross- cultural Communication: Perfect intercultural communication, according to Gudykunst and Kim (2003), is a process of stress management, motivation maintenance, and development of appropriate skills and competencies. CQ, or the ability to function well in cultural contexts, has a close relationship with cultural intelligence. I'll focus on being more open-minded, as well as developing my observational abilities and empathy, in order to raise my CQ and adjust to British classroom norms about time management and group projects.

Problem B

Importance of intercultural communication in this context

The modern world requires intercultural communication as a vital skill because it enables productive interactions among people from different backgrounds in academic environments and professional workplaces as well as social contexts. Students and professionals from Bangladesh interacting with counterparts in Japan must have knowledge about both cultural values and communication styles with social norms to avoid mistakes and show respect.

The lack of cultural understanding makes a Bangladeshi person believe Japanese reserved behavior in communication indicates misunderstanding whereas Japanese culture defines this behavior as polite expression. The formal educational setting in Japan may raise concerns among Japanese students regarding Bangladeshi openness since they might perceive it as non-professional conduct.

An individual who develops intercultural communication abilities learns to modify their actions and achieve emotional connection while managing their nervousness to enhance teamwork interactions. The skills are fundamental for success in academic exchange programs together with multinational teamwork and global diplomacy because they help people handle cultural differences.

Using Hofstede's Six Dimensions to Understand the Situation

Hofstede's six cultural dimensions establish a system to examine value disparities between communities. This model allows us to examine Bangladesh together with Japan so we can identify cultural behaviors and communication styles by their root causes.

1. **Power Distance:** While both nations allow such arrangements, Bangladesh's power distribution hierarchy is more established than Japan's. Bangladeshi students find it easier to adjust to the Japanese system when they are aware of the hierarchy variations in structures and the strict discipline that exists between the two cultures.
2. **Individualism vs. Collectivism:** Bangladeshi culture leans toward collectivism by promoting family ties as well as group unity while Japan upholds collectivism but adds personal accountability to its core values. Knowledge of these cultural differences enables people to prevent mistaken interpretations which commonly emerge in group assignments regarding team member responsibilities.
3. **Masculinity:** the Japanese workforce shows marked masculine traits because the people value achievement goals over everything else. The social structure of Bangladesh adopts a moderate approach between attaining success while maintaining care for others. Motivation levels together with leadership standards and achievement criteria experience direct influence from this phenomenon.
4. **Uncertainty Avoidance:** Strict regulations and a well-organized structure are necessary due to Japan's high degree of uncertainty avoidance. Bangladeshi students will need to modify their behavioral patterns to fit the cautious, rule-based culture of Japanese academic institutions and professional employment.
5. **Long-term Orientation:** Japanese society puts great importance on making plans that reach into the distant future along with maintaining steady determination. The assessment of Bangladesh at a moderate level indicates its institutions maintain brief planning periods in comparison. Japanese and Bangladeshi students experience different academic and career progress because of varying goals in decision-making and planning for the future.

6. **Indulgence:** In these two countries, the cultural ranking for enjoyment is at its lowest, indicating a focus on obedience and self-control. When circumstances call for patience, obligation, and modesty, people who are aware of this cultural connection will grow to understand one another.

Conclusion

The ability to communicate across cultures stands essential when dealing with various multicultural environments. When Bangladeshi students adjust to UK and Japanese educational environments the knowledge of cultural patterns and social customs and communication patterns helps create harmonious relationships between them. People who use cultural relativism together with CQ and Hofstede's dimensions create better connections which leads to success in diverse environments.

References:

1. <https://www.scirp.org/reference/referencespapers?referenceid=3020187>
2. <https://www.hofstede-insights.com/country-comparison/>
3. Ting-Toomey, S. (2012). *Understanding intercultural communication* (2nd ed.). Oxford University Press.
4. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/273115675_Intercultural_competence_Interpersonal_communication_across_culture_7th_edition

Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- Understanding Cultural Differences
- I learned that avoiding judgment based on my own cultural standards is important.
- Understanding another culture within its own context can help reduce misunderstandings and promote respect.
- Developing Cultural Intelligence
- Adapting Communication in Global Environments